Sound

Sources of Film Sound

By *source*, we mean “the location from which a sound originates.” Obviously, as mentioned already, most of the sounds heard in a movie literally originate from postproduction processes. The terms used to describe the source of a movie sound are *diegetic* or *nondiegetic*, *on-screen* or *offscreen*, and *internal* or *external*.

Diegetic vs. Nondiegetic Sound

The word diegesis refers to the total world of a film’s story, consisting perceptually of figures, motion, color, and sound. Diegetic sounds come from a source within a film’s world; they are the sounds heard by both the movie’s audience and characters. Nondiegetic sounds, which come from a source outside that world, are heard only by the audience. Most diegetic sound gives us an awareness of both the spatial and the temporal dimensions of the shot from which the sound emanates; most nondiegetic sound has no relevant spatial or temporal dimensions.

In John Schlesinger’s *Midnight Cowboy* (1969), right after stepping in front of an oncoming car (which screeches to a halt and honks its horn), “Ratso” Rizzo (Dustin Hoffman, right) interrupts his conversation with Joe Buck (Jon Voight, left) to shout one of the most famous movie lines of all time: “I’m walkin’ here!”

***Midnight Cowboy* (John Schlesinger, 1969)**

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Even surrounded by everyday Manhattan pedestrian and traffic noise, Rizzo's nasal voice and heavy "Noo Yawk" accent help characterize him as the extremely eccentric and comic foil to Buck, a new and unseasoned arrival in the big city.

Diegetic Sound in Action

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Diegetic sound can be either internal or external, on-screen or offscreen, and recorded during production or constructed during postproduction. The most familiar kind of movie sound is diegetic, on-screen sound that occurs simultaneously with the image. All of the

sounds that accompany everyday actions and speech depicted on-screen—footsteps on pavement, a knock on a door, the ring of a telephone, the report from a fired gun, ordinary dialogue—are diegetic.

A scene in Bo Burnham's *Eighth Grade* (2018) uses our expectations of diegetic sound and fidelity to punctuate the protagonist's distressing discovery after she looks up a term she does not know but has unwittingly claimed to perform. When she realizes that she's boasted about a sex act, Kayla slams her laptop shut—and we hear a loud, echoing, percussive thump. The surprising sound could not have realistically come from her little computer, but it effectively conveys her shock and dismay. As the movie (and its sound) continues, we realize the surprising thump was the first beat of what turns out to be nondiegetic score music.

***Eighth Grade* (Bo Burnham, 2018)**

Nondiegetic sound is offscreen and recorded during postproduction, and it is assumed to be inaudible to the characters on-screen. The most familiar forms of nondiegetic sound are musical scores and narration spoken by a voice that does not originate from the same place and time as the characters on the screen.

The Lobster (2015; director Yorgos Lanthimos) is a dystopian satire depicting a world in which unpaired adults are forced to stay at a remote resort. Those who cannot find a suitable (and willing) partner within 45 days are forcibly transformed into animals. The sappy romantic music we hear in a scene in which the mostly doomed single residents attend a dance lends a sense of irony to their absurd and sad situation. This music is clearly sourced

in the scene and is thus diegetic. But when the protagonist, David, crosses the dance floor in search of a potential partner, the band's diegetic song is temporarily replaced by dramatic—and nondiegetic—orchestral score music that emphasizes his anxiety in this high-stakes situation.

***The Lobster* (Yorgos Lanthimos, 2015)**

On-Screen vs. Offscreen Sound

On-screen sound emanates from a source that we can see. Offscreen sound, which can be either diegetic or nondiegetic, derives from a source that we do not see. When offscreen sound is diegetic, it consists of sound effects, music, or vocals that emanate from the world of the story. When nondiegetic, it takes the form of a musical score or narration by someone who is not a character in the story. Simultaneous sound comes from the world of the story and thus is diegetic; it is presented to the audience at the same time as the corresponding image. Nonsimultaneous sound is also from the world of the story (diegetic), but is sourced from some other time (usually earlier) in that story. Nonsimultaneous sound is often used to provide plot information without the viewer actually having to witness the source events taking place.

This brings us to asynchronous sound, which is sound that intentionally exploits a discrepancy between a presented sound and the images and action on-screen. Because we cannot see its source, asynchronous sound seems mysterious and raises our curiosity and expectations. Thus it offers creative opportunities for building tension and surprise in a

scene. We can insert an asynchronous sound into our hypothetical (and increasingly depressing) film.

Offscreen sounds play a significant role in Robert Bresson's *A Man Escaped* (1956), the story of a member of the French Resistance being held in a Nazi prison camp during World War II. Once he enters the prison, much of his (and our) experience of the world outside his cell is limited to offscreen sound.

***A Man Escaped* (Robert Bresson, 1956)**

Most movies provide a blend of offscreen and on-screen sounds that seems very natural and verisimilar, leading us to almost overlook the distinction between them. Some uses of sound, however, call attention to themselves; for example, when a scene favors offscreen sounds or excludes on-screen sounds altogether, we usually take notice.

Internal vs. External Sound

An internal sound occurs whenever we hear what we assume are the thoughts of a character within a scene. The character might be expressing random thoughts or a sustained monologue. In the theater, when Shakespeare wants us to hear a character's thoughts, he uses a soliloquy to convey them, but this device lacks verisimilitude. Laurence Olivier's many challenges in adapting *Hamlet* for the screen included making the title character's soliloquies acceptable to a movie audience that might not be familiar with

theatrical conventions. Olivier wanted to show Hamlet as both a thinker whose psychology motivated his actions and a man who could not make up his mind. Thus in his *Hamlet* (1948), Olivier (as Hamlet) delivered the greatest of all Shakespearean soliloquies—"To be, or not to be"—in a combination of both spoken lines and interior monologue. This innovation influenced the use of internal sound in countless other movies, including subsequent cinematic adaptations of Shakespeare's plays.

After Collin, the protagonist of *Blindspotting* (2018; director Carlos López Estrada), witnesses police shooting an unarmed man, sound places us inside his anxious state of mind. As we watch Collin silently slump on his halfway house bed, the external sound of his offscreen parole officer's diatribe is gradually overwhelmed by an internal cacophony of low rumbling tones and blaring horns.

***Blindspotting* (Carlos López Estrada, 2018)**

External sound comes from a place within the world of the story, and we assume that it is heard by the characters in that world. The source of an external sound can be either on-screen or offscreen. In John Ford's *My Darling Clementine* (1946), a man referred to as "Indian Charlie" is drunk and shooting up the town of Tombstone. The townspeople are afraid of Charlie, and the sheriff resigns rather than confront him; so Wyatt Earp—who is both on-screen and offscreen during the scene—is appointed sheriff and takes it upon himself to stop the chaos that Charlie has created.

***My Darling Clementine* (John Ford, 1946)**

The scene effectively combines both on-screen and offscreen sounds. The characters (and the viewer) hear the offscreen sounds of Charlie shooting his gun inside the saloon followed by the offscreen sounds of women screaming; then the women appear on-screen as they run from the saloon with Charlie right behind them, still shooting his gun. When Earp, on-screen, starts to enter the building through an upstairs window, we hear the offscreen screams of the prostitutes who are in the room as he says, “Sorry, ladies.” Offscreen, Earp confronts Charlie and conks him on the head, for we hear the thud of Charlie falling to the saloon floor. This is followed by an on-screen shot of Earp dragging Charlie out of the saloon to the waiting crowd. This use of sound demonstrates Earp’s courage and skill while treating his serious encounter with Charlie with a comic touch.